

- **AnTuTu:** 2,151,792 (iPhone 17) vs 1,631,715 (iPhone 16) — a 32% jump.
- **Geekbench Single-Core:** 3,595 vs 3,137 — about 15% faster.
- **Geekbench Multi-Core:** 9,034 vs 7,642 — a 18% improvement.
- **3DMark Wildlife Extreme:** 4,787 vs 3,906 — 22% more GPU muscle.

In daily use, the difference is obvious in the small things: apps open a split-second quicker, Safari tabs with heavy media stay alive longer in memory, and games like Genshin Impact or Call of Duty: Warzone Mobile hold higher frame rates with fewer drops.

Thermals remain in check too. Even during a 20-minute 3DMark stress test, the iPhone 17 sustained about 91% of peak performance, compared to the iPhone 16 which dipped closer to 85%. That means fewer slowdowns under sustained gaming or video editing loads. The iPhone 17 does get warm when running benchmarks, recording long 4K Dolby Vision clips, or charging, though it's not alarming, but I'd love to see Apple address heat dissipation on the base models the way they've done on the Pros by introducing a vapour cooling system, like some Android rivals do. If there's one nitpick: while the A19 and iOS 26 can clearly handle gaming, the iPhone 17 still caps BGMI at 60fps. It's buttery and stable, but also a strange limitation on hardware this capable.

Apple has rebuilt the software experience with what it calls the Liquid Glass interface: a slicker, more fluid visual style that pairs beautifully with the new 120Hz display. It's customisable, with spatial wallpapers and lock screen tweaks that make iOS feel less rigid.

CAMERAS

Another area where Apple delivered is that they finally made the ultrawide lens 48MP instead of the old 12MP token camera. The difference is immediate: sharper landscapes, more detail in group shots, and ultrawide images that don't look like a blurry afterthought.

The main wide camera stays at 48MP but benefits from better colour calibration, especially in low light. Night mode



shots look more natural, with less of that aggressive smoothing that used to make neon signs look AI-generated. It sticks to what iPhones do best: balanced shots with excellent dynamic range. Compared to the iPhone 16, you'll notice more natural skin tones, tighter detail, and less aggressive sharpening. Portrait mode has improved too. Edge detection is more confident, bokeh looks smoother, and skin tones come out more lifelike even in dodgy lighting.

The real surprise is the selfie camera. It jumps from 12MP to 18MP and uses a square sensor, which means you don't have to awkwardly tilt your wrist to frame group selfies. Adding Center Stage is a clever addition and the front camera finally feels Pro-tier. It tracks and adjusts as you move, which not only makes video calls more dynamic but also works well for group selfies.

Video is still Apple's stronghold: Dolby Vision HDR, stabilisation that makes shots look gimbal-smooth, and Dual Capture lets you record from front and back cameras at once. Android phones have had this for years, but on the iPhone 17 it feels polished.

VERDICT

One of the most underrated upgrades with the iPhone 17 is that it now starts at 256GB storage so it won't fill up the second you shoot a holiday's worth of 4K video. Prices start at ₹82,900 for 256GB and ₹1,02,900 for 512GB.

For over a decade, recommending the regular iPhone always came with caveats. It's good, but... no ProMotion. It's fine, but... the cameras are held back. It's reliable, but... you'll be deleting files on that stingy 128GB model in six months. The base iPhone was never bad, but it was always a bit of a compromise.

Between the 120Hz ProMotion display, the brighter 6.3-inch screen, the A19 chip's power, a useful ultrawide camera, an upgraded selfie shooter with Center Stage, bigger base storage, and a durable battery Apple has bridged the gap that used to separate the "regular" iPhone from its Pro siblings.

That doesn't mean the Pro models are obsolete, you still don't get the telephoto lens, Pro video capabilities, vapour cooling system, USB 3.2 transfer speeds, or the Pro SoC. But for once, those feel like luxuries, not essentials. The iPhone 17 gives you the complete experience at ₹82,900, without the sting of knowing what you're missing.

If you're on an iPhone 13 or 14, this is the year to upgrade. The 17 feels like Apple listened. For the first time in a long time, the base iPhone is not just the safe choice, it's the sensible pick.

—Siddharth Chauhan

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Apple A19 | RAM: 12 GB LPDDR5X | Storage 256GB, 512GB, 1TB | OS: iOS 26 | Display: 6.3-inch OLED HDR display, 2622 x 1206 pixels | Refresh Rate: 1-120 Hz | IP Rating: IP68 | Cameras: 48 MP Fusion | Selfie Camera: 18 MP Centre Stage | Video: Up to 4K at 60 fps | Battery Capacity: 3,692 mAh

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